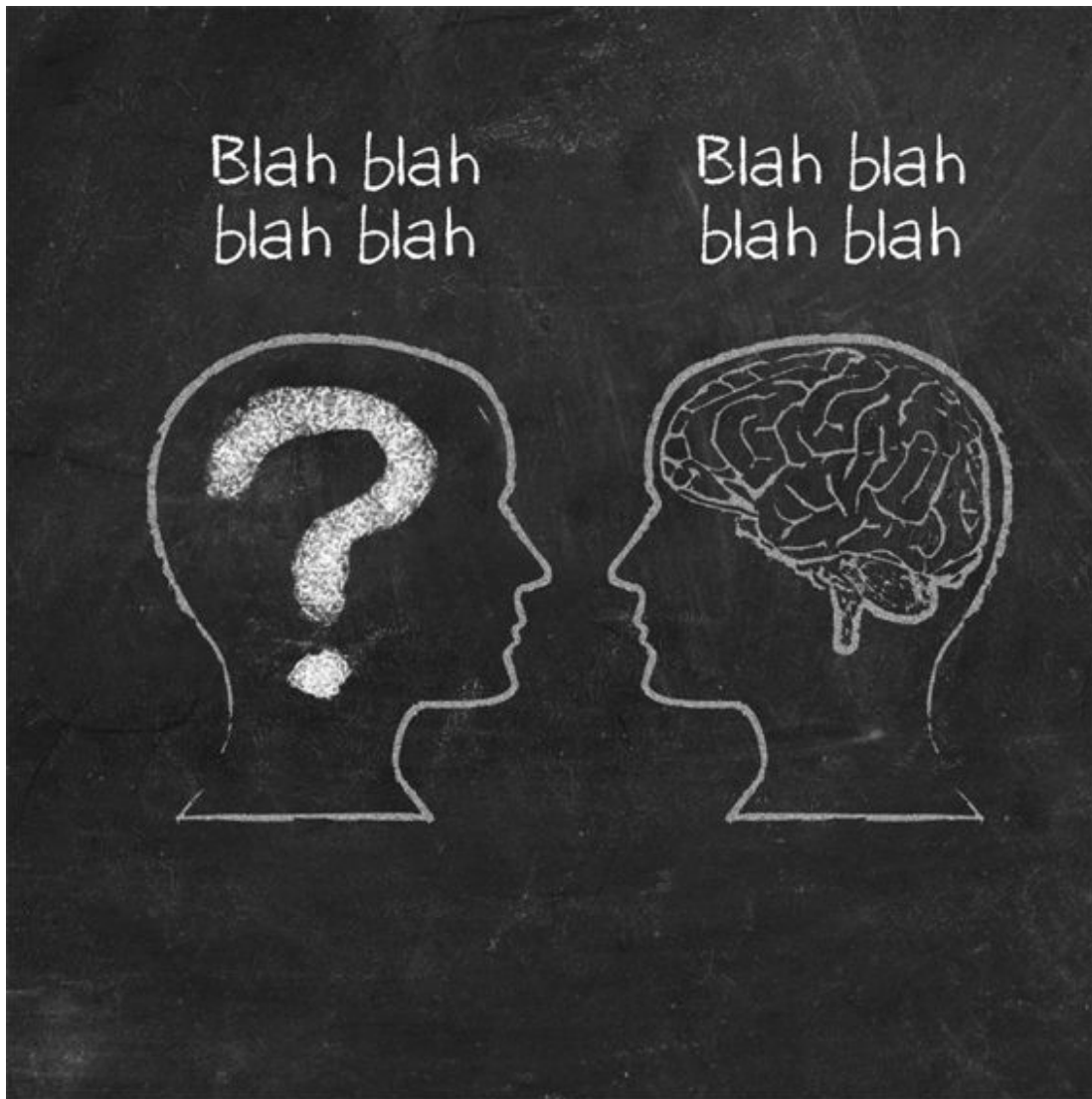


Other people's minds and consciousness



With his '*Cogito, ergo sum*', Descartes proved his own existence: he showed that the 'I' of 'I think' and 'I am' exists as a thinking thing, a mind. But there is a problem with this sort of introspective reasoning. I know that I exist, and so have consciousness, but that does not prove that anybody else has; it would be wrong to assume on the evidence of a single example that this is a general rule. Common sense may persuade me that all human beings (and maybe even animals, see [Animal rights](#)) have the same sort of minds because they appear to me to exhibit consciousness, but that doesn't give me sufficient grounds for *believing* that they have. It may be that there

are some people – philosophers call them ‘zombies’ – who show all the outward signs of consciousness, such as wincing with pain, laughter and so on, but actually have no consciousness. Perhaps everyone else is a zombie – I can never be sure. And even if they do have minds, I cannot know that the mental experiences of others are the same as mine; what I see as ‘red’, for example, another person might see as my ‘green’.